

Drop the rake, hit the brakes, drive South Fork



Photos by Jeff Petersen, special to the Walla Walla Union-Bulletin

Elk gather at a South Fork lunch buffet.

I drive slowly along the South Fork of the Walla Walla River road. There is no fast lane where I am going. Alluring views unfold around each corner, from tree-lined stream to arid, basalt-encrusted hills, on this 13-mile adventure linking the south end of Milton-Freewater and Harris Park.



Day Tripper

Jeff Petersen

The air is crisp. Cottonwoods are starting the annual fall gold rush. A brooding sky looms. The 40 mph-speed limit road winds past basalt cliffs and boulder-choked torrents. The down-sweeping slopes are a mixture of basalt ramparts, open grassland and tree-lined tributaries, now mostly dry. I pass a dilapidated barn sprouting vegetation from its roof and a herd of Scottish Highland cows. As I near Harris Park, the end

of the road, the canyon deepens. When I stop and pull off the road, it is eerily quiet except for the rush of the enlivened river as it plunges downhill toward an ultimate meetup with the Columbia upstream from Wallula Gap. The foaming torrent here will soon rest behind a series of dams. At Harris Park, I park the car, get out and stretch. Pine trees cast long shadows. Trembling hardwood leaves are turning colors and beginning to parachute to the ground. Some leaves are falling into the river and becoming colorful boats. The river is running low in fall, but still carries plenty of water; thanks to the reliable basalt aquifer. After walking around some, exploring and taking a few breaths of the bracing air, I hop in the car and drive the meandering road back downhill. The park sits at about 2,300 feet above sea level, while Milton-Freewater is at about 1,000. The Harris Park road provides the opportunity to look for wildlife. Deer, elk, bear, wild turkey and much more make their home in the valley and adjacent hillsides. I pass neat farms nestled along the river, with alpacas and horses grazing. Farther down I pass a winery, peaceful meadows, colorful sumac groves and pine-covered hills. A speed limit of 40 mph reminds of national parks where drivers are forced to slow down and smell the sage. (The speed limit also helps protect



Fawns play in sprinklers along the South Fork road.



The South Fork of the Walla Walla River bubbles along near Harris Park.



A goat ventures outdoors to keep an eye on the infrequent traffic.



A creeping thistle blooms along the South Fork.

GARDENING

Transplanting shrubs: Timing and technique for a thriving garden

JESSICA DAMIANO
ASSOCIATED PRESS

It's the end of the gardening season, and those of us who've endured a less-than-perfect layout may be itching to move shrubs around. But proper timing is imperative. I inadvertently planted a Clethra bush too close to a peach tree, and their intertwining branches have been taunting me all summer. But because the Clethra is a late-season bloomer, I'll have to wait a bit longer before I can safely move it. As a general rule, shrubs (and perennials) that bloom in late summer and fall should be transplanted in spring, just after they emerge from dormancy. This timing provides ample time for roots to establish before the plant's energy is redirected toward blooming. Spring and early summer bloomers should be relocated in the fall, when their blossoms and, sometimes, foliage, are long gone.

Start with roots

Before attempting to dig up shrubs, research how deep and wide their roots typically grow. Shallow-rooted shrubs, like rhododendron, for instance, are easier to dig up than, say, manzanita, which have very deep root systems. Take the



A shovel plunges into soil around a cherry laurel shrub.

plant's age into account, too, as mature shrubs will have larger roots than younger ones. Your findings will guide your digging: New holes should be as close to twice the width of roots as possible — and exactly as deep. Always dig a hole for the plant's new home before removing it from the ground to minimize root exposure.

When possible, gently tie the plant's branches together to get a better view of the area you're digging. This step also helps prevent eye injuries from errant stems. Take care to dig up as much of the roots as possible, plunging a sharp-edged shovel into the soil at what you estimate to be the roots' farthest point and

working your way around the perimeter of the plant. Then, retrace your steps, this time with more force to insert the tool deeply enough to lift

roots out of the ground from underneath. **Tips on planting** To avoid losing soil and damaging roots — as well as your back — place the entire shrub onto a tarp and drag the tarp to the new hole you've prepared. Carefully slide the rootball into the hole and assess its depth. If necessary, remove the plant from the hole to add or remove soil as needed to ensure the point where its roots meet the trunk —the plant's crown —sits at the same level it was previously. Plant too deeply, and the crown and trunk will eventually rot; too shallow, and the roots will dry out, suffer sun and cold damage, and struggle to spread horizontally. When you're satisfied the shrub is sitting straight and

at the correct depth, begin backfilling the hole with soil, stopping periodically to firmly tamp it down to eliminate air pockets. Water the soil halfway through, then resume backfilling and tamping. Water the soil again, then apply mulch over the entire root zone to retain soil moisture, regulate soil temperature and repel weeds. Water the plant regularly through frost during the entire first year in its new home, but don't fertilize yet. Apply a slow-release, low-nitrogen fertilizer in mid- to late spring. Doing so earlier would force the plant to allocate its limited energy to growth rather than recovery and root development. Allowing transplants time to settle in can mean the difference between a struggling shrub and one that thrives for years to come.



Clay in Motion
Pottery Studio

IT'S LOOKING
A LOT LIKE
CHRISTMAS!

WWW.412573



THE PROVOST TEAM
your location

WWW.292319

Are you curious
about what your
home is worth
in today's
Market?

Susan Akers
Broker/ Realtor®
(509) 520-3885
Susan@Susanakers.com